Excel Merge Tool

User guide · version 2.1

What it does

You keep a master workbook. Colleagues send back spreadsheets with updates against the same IDs. This tool lines the two up by an ID (key) column and copies the values you choose into your master: either **replacing** the old value or **appending** to it. Think of it as a careful clerk who reads each returned form, finds the matching line in your ledger and writes in only the boxes you told them to, without touching the ledger's layout.

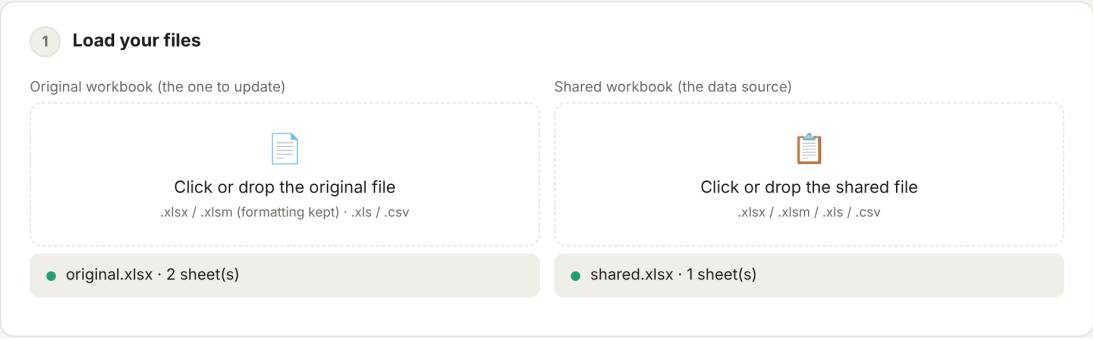
Before you start

- Open **excel-merge-tool.html** in Chrome, Edge or Firefox (double-click). No install and no internet needed.
- Save your master as **.xlsx** or **.xlsm** so formatting is kept. (.xls and .csv still merge, but the output loses formatting.)
- Make sure both files have a header row and a column with the same IDs (names can differ, e.g. *Reqt_ID* and *Requirement ID*).
- You do not need to close the master in Excel: the tool never changes your original file; it downloads a new copy.

Your files stay on your computer. The tool makes no network connections.

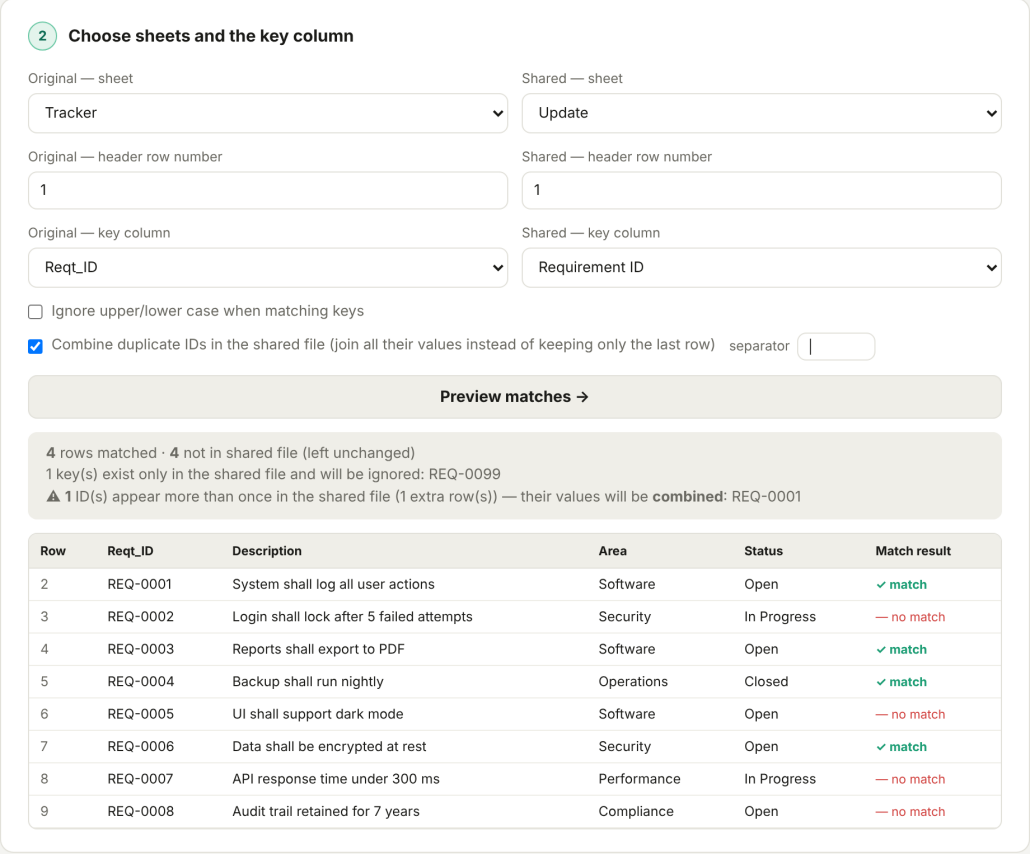
Step 1 — Load your files

Click (or drag a file onto) the left box for the **original** workbook you want to update, and the right box for the **shared** workbook that holds the new data. A green dot confirms each file and shows how many sheets it has.



Step 2 — Choose sheets and the key column

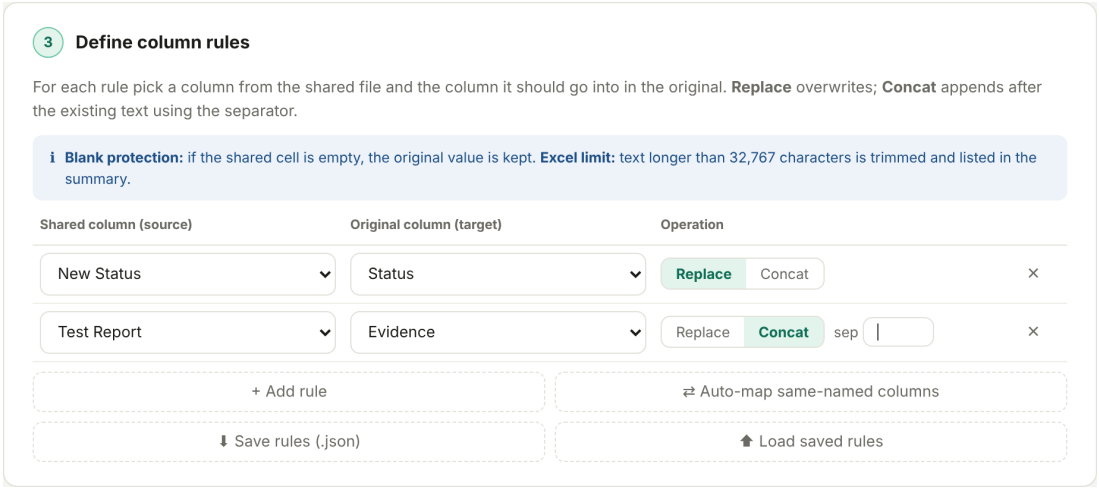
- **Sheet**: the tab to use in each file.
- **Header row number**: change it if your column titles are not on row 1 (e.g. a title block above the table).
- **Key column**: the ID column in each file. The tool pre-selects common names such as *Reqt_ID* or *ID*.
- **Ignore upper/lower case**: tick if one file has *req-001* and the other *REQ-001*. Extra spaces are always ignored.
- **Combine duplicate IDs** (ticked by default): if the shared file has the same ID on several rows, all their values are joined using the *separator* box, e.g. *Report A | Report B*. Empty cells and repeated values are skipped. Untick it to use only the last row for each ID.
- Click **Preview matches**. Read the summary line: rows matched, rows not in the shared file, IDs only in the shared file, and how many IDs are duplicated in the shared file (and whether they will be combined).



Step 3 — Define column rules

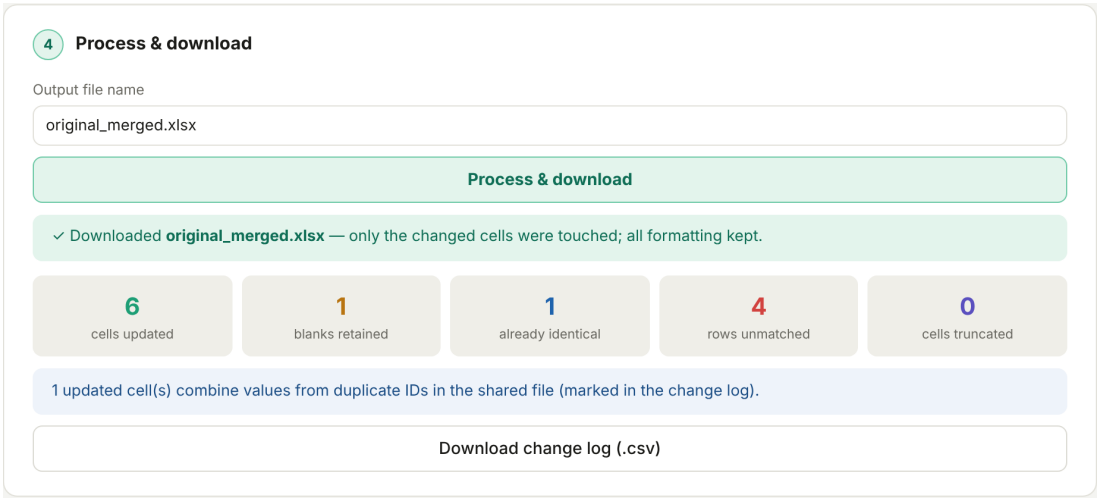
Each rule says: take this column from the shared file and put it into that column of the original.

- **Replace** overwrites the target cell.
- **Concat** keeps the existing text and appends the new value after the separator (default **|**). Edit the *sep* box to use e.g. **;** or a line break.
- **+ Add rule** for more columns; **×** removes a rule.
- **Auto-map same-named columns** adds Replace rules for every column that has the identical title in both files.
- **Save rules (.json)** stores the whole set-up (sheets, header rows, keys, rules). Next month, load both files, click Preview, then **Load saved rules**.



Step 4 — Process & download

Check the output file name and click **Process & download**. The merged copy downloads immediately and a summary appears.



Reading the summary

Figure	Meaning
Cells updated	Cells that received a new value.
Blanks retained	Shared cell was empty, so the original value was kept.
Already identical	Value was already the same; nothing written.
Rows unmatched	Rows in your original whose ID is not in the shared file; left untouched.
Combined cells (note below the figures)	Cells whose new value was joined from duplicate IDs; each is marked in the change log.
Cells truncated	Text exceeded Excel's 32,767-character cell limit and was trimmed. Each one is listed.

Click **Download change log (.csv)** for a record of every change: ID, column, cell, operation, old value and new value. Keep it with your submission as an audit trail.

Rules the tool follows

Situation	What happens
ID found, shared cell has a value	Replace or Concat, as set in the rule
ID found, shared cell is blank	Original value kept
ID not in shared file	Row unchanged
ID only in shared file	Ignored (listed in the preview)
Same ID twice in the original	Every copy is updated
Same ID on several rows of the shared file (Combine ticked)	All non-blank values joined with the combine separator, repeats dropped. With Concat, the joined text goes after the existing value
Same ID on several rows of the shared file (Combine unticked)	The last row wins
Plain number in shared file (Replace)	Written as a number, so sums still work

What is kept, and what to check

- Kept: fills, fonts, borders, column widths, row heights, freeze panes, filters, drop-down validation, merged cells, other sheets, charts, pivots and macros (.xlsm).
- Formulas that depend on changed cells recalculate when you open the file.
- Fixed cell colours do not change with the value: a red 'Open' cell stays red after becoming 'Closed'. Use conditional formatting if colours should follow the status.
- If a target cell held a formula, it now holds the merged value (the summary says how many).
- Pivot tables show old figures until you click **Data** → **Refresh All** in Excel.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Cause and fix
0 rows matched	Wrong key column or header row selected, or IDs differ in case. Re-check step 2; tick Ignore case.
Column missing in the dropdown	Header row number is wrong, or the title cell is blank. Set the correct header row.
Warning that formatting cannot be kept	Original is .xls or .csv. Open it in Excel, Save As .xlsx, and load that copy.
Saved rules load with columns skipped	A column was renamed since you saved. Re-add that rule and save again.
Excel shows old pivot values	Pivots are not refreshed automatically: Data → Refresh All.